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Newsom Approves $2.5 Billion for Recovery Package in L.A. County

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In a move to assist Los Angeles County in its recovery from recent firestorms that devastated tens of thousands of residents, Gov. Gavin Newsom signed a $2.5 billion bipartisan relief package on Jan. 23.

Flanked by legislative leaders, local officials, and community advocates, Newsom assured the affected communities that help is on the way.

"This $2.5 billion relief package will immediately bolster emergency response efforts, remove debris, and provide funding to rebuild homes, schools, and infrastructure," said Newsom at the bill signing at Willard Elementary School in Pasadena. "We want to make sure Los Angeles comes back stronger than ever."

The relief package, authorized under ABx1–4, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) and SBx13 by Sen. Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco), provides critical resources to address the firestorm's impact.

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A total of $2.5 billion has been designated for emergency response efforts, debris removal, hazard mitigation, and shelter support for displaced residents. Additionally, $4 million has been allocated to expedite rebuilding efforts by providing planning and inspection resources to local governments, ensuring a swift recovery. Another $1 million is earmarked for the rebuilding of fire-damaged school facilities, particularly benefiting the Los Angeles Unified and Pasadena Unified school districts.

In addition to these funds, Newsom issued executive orders last week to provide tax relief for affected residents; streamline rebuilding by suspending CEQA permitting requirements; and protect survivors from price gouging. In collaboration with major mortgage lenders, the state has also introduced mortgage relief options for homeowners who have suffered losses due to the disaster.

Among the communities most impacted by the disaster is Altadena, an unincorporated area adjacent to Pasadena, home to a thriving historically Black neighborhood. Beginning in the early 20th century, Altadena became a refuge for Black American families facing housing discrimination elsewhere due to redlining. Altadena remains an enclave of middle-class Black families where the Black homeownership rate outpaces that of other cities and towns in California and around the country.

The devastation from the fires has left many of the affected families in Pasadena and Altadena pondering options to rebuild as they contemplate how they will protect the historic area's rich Black history.

"Altadena is more than just a neighborhood. It's a living history of Black excellence and perseverance," said local community leader the Rev. James Daniels. "This relief package is critical to ensuring families can rebuild, stay in their homes, and preserve this legacy."

Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass expressed gratitude for the swift response from state leadership.

"This package will allow us to move forward urgently with cleanup efforts and help families rebuild their lives," she said.

Residents and business owners impacted by the firestorm can apply for disaster assistance through multiple channels. Online applications can be submitted at DisasterAssistance.gov, while phone assistance is available by calling 800-621-3362.

The FEMA Mobile App, which provides resources in over 40 languages, is also accessible to those seeking aid. Additionally, the state has launched CA.gov/LAfires, a centralized hub offering information on housing assistance, financial relief programs, and guidance on rebuilding efforts.

Newsom emphasized that this funding is only the beginning of the state's commitment to rebuilding Los Angeles.

"We want to ensure that we don't just provide relief today but continue supporting communities in the long run," he stated. As state officials assess additional recovery needs, Newsom pledged to seek further support from federal agencies and private sector partners to ensure a comprehensive and sustained rebuilding process.

The same day, Bass shared some good news from the Small Business Administration (SBA) for families impacted by the fires on the social media platform X.

"SBAgov has approved $52 million in disaster loans," she wrote. More than $50 million of that is for homeowners and renters. Apply for relief: sba.gov/disaster. The deadline to apply is March 10."

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